

CHAPTER FIVE

Oops vs. I Am Bad

Kenji is not in Room 12.

Kenji is in the other first-grade class, down the hall, with Jaylen and his block tower. We mention him here because something happened to Kenji on the playground on a Wednesday in October that the kids in Room 12 saw, and they brought what they saw back into the classroom. What happened was this. Kenji told a secret that his best friend Elijah had told him not to tell. The secret was not a big one — it was that Elijah was getting a puppy on Saturday. Kenji had been so excited that he had told three other kids before he remembered that Elijah had said do not tell anyone.

When Elijah found out, on the slide, Elijah did not yell. Elijah just turned away from Kenji and went to play with somebody else.

Kenji stood by himself on the slide for almost five minutes. Then he came inside, and he sat down on the carpet of his own classroom, and he started to cry, and the thing he said over and over — loud enough that the kids in Room 12 heard it through the wall — was: I am a TERRIBLE person. I ruin everything. I am the WORST friend. The kids in Room 12 were quiet. Even Jordan was quiet.

Ms. Calloway took Sammy out of the box.

"Friends," said Sammy, "I want to tell you about a thing that just happened next door. A friend over there did a thing that

was not okay. He told a secret he should not have told. That is true. He needs to apologize. That is true. But here is what is also true: he just said something about himself that is not true. He said I am a terrible person. That is the part I want to talk about."

Sammy let the room get quiet.

"There are two ways to be sorry," said Sammy. "There is Oops. And there is I Am Bad. They feel almost the same. But they are not the same. They are very, very different. And one of them helps you, and the other one hurts you."

Ms. Calloway held up two pieces of paper.

On one piece, in big letters, it said: OOPS.

On the other, in big letters, it said: I AM BAD.

"Oops," said Sammy, "is when you say: I did a thing that was not okay. I am sorry. I am going to make it right. Oops is about WHAT YOU DID. Oops makes you stronger. Oops helps you fix the thing."

"I Am Bad," said Sammy, "is when you say: I am a terrible person. I always mess up. I ruin everything. I Am Bad is about WHO YOU ARE. I Am Bad does not help you fix anything. I Am Bad just makes you feel small. I Am Bad makes it harder to do the next right thing." Sammy paused.

"Friends, here is the secret. Everybody does Oopses. Everybody. Adults do them. Children do them. Teachers do them. Sammy does them — Sammy is a puppet and Sammy still does them. Oopses are part of being a person. Oopses are how we learn. An Oops is not who you are. An Oops is a thing you did."

"When you do an Oops," said Sammy, "you say Oops. You make it right. And then — and this is important — you let it go. You do NOT carry the Oops around like it is who you are."

Marcus, who was thinking very hard about the block tower from a few weeks ago, raised his hand.

"What if it was a big Oops?" Marcus said. "Like a really, really big one?"

Ms. Calloway came over. She crouched down next to Marcus.

"Even a big Oops, Marcus, is still an Oops. Even a big Oops is still a thing you DID, not who you ARE. The bigger the Oops, the more important it is to remember the difference. Because if you tell yourself a big Oops means you are bad — you have a much harder time making the Oops right."

Marcus nodded. He did not say anything else. But Ms. Calloway saw, on her way back to the front of the room, that Marcus was sitting up a little taller than he had been. Whatever the weight was that he had been carrying — Ms. Calloway did not know what it was, and she would not have asked — that weight was a little smaller now.

This is the moment the Mistake Wall first started.

Ms. Calloway taped a long sheet of butcher paper to the back wall of Room 12. At the top, she wrote: THE MISTAKE WALL — Oopses, Big and Small.

"For the rest of the year," she said, "any time somebody in Room 12 has an Oops they want to put on the wall — they can. Anonymously. We will not put names. We will not point fingers. We will just say: here is an Oops that happened. And then we will write next to it what we DID to make it right. So we can see, all year, that Oopses happen, and Oopses get fixed, and Oopses do not make anybody bad."

The first Oops on the Mistake Wall was written by Ms. Calloway herself.

It said: I forgot to send home the field-trip permission slip on Monday. I sent it home on Tuesday. I told the parents I was

sorry it was late. I am going to put a reminder in my planner so I do not forget next time. Ms. Calloway turned around and looked at the kids.

"That was my Oops this week," she said. "Now you know one of mine. Whose Oops is next?"

Marcus put his hand up.

He did not say what his Oops was out loud. But he came up to the wall, very quietly, and he wrote — in his slow, careful, six-year-old handwriting:

I knocked over a friend's block tower in September. I said sorry. We rebuilt it. I walk slower past blocks now.

He stepped back.

Ms. Calloway read it once. She did not say anything. She just nodded. That was the first Oops on the wall.

It would not be the last.